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A security researcher found 13 apps on the Play Store hosting malware which was downloaded by 560,000 Android users. <https://dgit.in/dec18-45-2>

Searching documents

Now that we have learned about the basics of working with data in an Elasticsearch index let us move on to more exciting things - searching.

Before that, let us fill up our index with some documents with the requests shown here: <https://dgit.in/ES5>.

At this point, perhaps it is worth noting that instead of individual requests we can collate all of these documents into one single bulk request at the `(_bulk)` endpoint. However for the purposes of our tutorial this multiple requests approach will suffice.

_search endpoint

Now that we have some songs in our index, let's see if we can find them again by searching. In order to search we use the `_search` endpoint. That is, we make requests to an URL following this pattern: `<index>/<type>/_search` where index and type are optional.

Here are some example searches and their outputs:

- http://localhost:9200/_search - Search across all indexes and all types.
- http://localhost:9200/songs/_search - Search across all types in the songs index.
- http://localhost:9200/songs/rock/_search - Search explicitly for documents of type rock within the songs index.

ELASTICSEARCH QUERY DSL

Simply sending a request to one of the above URLs would not yield an effective search and instead simply return all our rock songs list. To make a more

useful search request we need to supply a request body with a query. The request body should be a JSON object which, among other things, can contain a property named "query" in which we can use Elasticsearch query DSL which is Elasticsearch's own domain specific language based on JSON in which queries and filters can be expressed.



Elasticsearch has many applications

Basic free text search

A simple free text search query involves searching for a given input text. Let's try a search for the word "Chor" which is present in the title of one of our songs, as shown here: <https://dgit.in/ES6>. Let's execute the request and take a look at the result.

Specifying fields to search in

Basic search uses a very simple query with only a single property, `query`.

We can also include a setting called `fields` that can be used to specify a list of fields to search in. If we don't use that the query will default to searching in a special field called `_all` that Elasticsearch automatically generates based on all of the individual fields in a document.

Let's try to search for songs only by year. That is, if we search for 2016 we want to get a hit for *Daniken* but not anything else.

There are a number of complex queries (and filters which are a separate area unto themselves) that you can run on Elasticsearch that can be used to query the indexed data in a multitude of useful ways. But for the sake of brevity in our tutorial, we will conclude the search subtopic here. The reader is encouraged to look up on all of Elasticsearch's available queries and try them out. Let us now discuss a few applications where we can put Elasticsearch to good use.

Applications for Elasticsearch

An online web store where you can search for products that you sell (read Amazon) is an ideal use case. In this case, you can use Elasticsearch to store your entire product catalog (running into millions) and inventory and provide search and autocomplete suggestions for them.

Store logs or transaction data and analyse and mine this data to look for trends, statistics, summaries, or anomalies. Once the data is in Elasticsearch, you can run complex searches and aggregations to mine any information that is of interest to you.

You have analytics/business-intelligence needs and want to quickly investigate, analyze, visualize, and query on a lot of data (think millions or billions of records). In this case, you can use Elasticsearch to store your data and then use Kibana which can be easily coupled with it.

Thus we see that Elasticsearch offers a veritable goldmine of capabilities for searching, querying and storing a large amount of data in a secure, distributed and fail-safe way. 🇮🇳

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